didn’t allow me to do so. The aim of playing straighter, being more still at the crease, might have worked on flat wickets in Bangladesh, but as soon as the ball moved, I needed greater dexterity.

When it nips about you have to ride it, adjust your hands. I was so rigid I was nicking it, with hard hands, to the slips or gully. I was trapped between theory and practice. I kept finding the fielder, banging balls at mid-on and mid-off. I had lost that intrinsic skill of being able to work the gap. I needed not to improvise, as such, but to rediscover the balance between risk and reward.

As a team we began to focus on what Andy Flower described as our super-strengths. These were definitive aspects of our talents, that separated us from the rest. Mine, as a batsman, were the consistency of the cut shot and the pull shot. How had I adapted those strengths as my career had progressed?

My leg-side play was efficient. If they bowled short at me, I didn’t get out that often and generally hit the average ball for four. If they bowled straight, at the line of middle stump, I wasn’t hitting the boundary as often as I had when I turned up on the scene. Certainly, in those early days, anyone who bowled at my legs was punished.

It was time to confront the Gimp, the imaginary tormentor who had been on my shoulder since childhood. He had grown with me from those games in the back garden, where he’d whispered idly about the shame of losing to my brothers. At that stage in our lives, though, he was a little more innocent, markedly less intense.

Rationalizing my relationship with self-doubt was the key to the longevity of my international career. I stopped stubbornly fighting it, grinding away at it. I knew the Gimp would continue to play devil’s advocate and attempt to sour any success. He’s a cheeky bastard who won’t leave you alone, a cartoon figure who dusts himself down and springs back at you when you’ve punched him a thousand times.

Everyone has one.

It had taken eight years, from 2003, to understand him. I accepted him without welcoming him. It’s no longer a case of flight or fight. There are days when I’m better than him and days when I go to bed angry because he has beaten me. He will never stop telling me I’ve lost it, that everyone will notice when I don’t get runs tomorrow.